



What is identity?

- 1 Study the reading strategy. Then read the online article for gist and choose the correct words in the summary.



Reading strategy

Reading for gist or detail

When we read for the general idea or gist, we don't focus on every word or piece of information. We use text structure, title, headings, content words, and any images to recognize the important ideas.

When we read for specific details, we need to read more slowly and with care. It's sometimes necessary to read part or all of the text more than once to check that we don't miss anything.

The article is about a ¹small / large number of people who have a ²learned / natural ability to recognize faces that they have ³often / briefly seen before and how they use their skills ⁴in the workplace / on TV.

- 2 Now read the article for specific details. Decide if these sentences are true (T) or false (F). Correct the false sentences.

- 1 The term "super recognizer" has been used since 2009.
- 2 Being a super recognizer is similar to having "prosopagnosia."
- 3 At present, there's one super recognizer working for the Metropolitan Police.
- 4 Super recognizers can identify people from old pictures.
- 5 Super recognizers can often identify people better than modern technology.
- 6 Porritt remembers having good recognizing skills in early adulthood.

- 3 Answer the questions.

- 1 Can anybody become a super recognizer? Why? / Why not?

- 2 How do you think the super recognizers in the Metropolitan Police spend a lot of their time?

- 3 Do super recognizers need to see a whole picture of a person? Why? / Why not?

- 4 What were the early signs that Porritt had good recognizing skills?

- 5 What is one of the main disadvantages of Porritt's job?

- 6 Give an example of something Paul has needed to do when he isn't working.

- 4 Answer the questions. Write your ideas below.

Look back at the questions at the beginning of the article. Do you think you are a super recognizer? Explain why / why not.

What would be some of the advantages and disadvantages in your daily life of being a super recognizer? Give different examples.

ARE YOU A SUPER RECOGNIZER?

Can you:

- recognize the faces of people that you haven't seen for a very long time?
- identify faces that you've only seen once for a short time?
- recognize unknown actors who play small parts in different movies?
- see the similarity in the faces of people who are from the same family?



If the answer is "yes" to these questions, then you might be a "super recognizer" – a person who has the unusual ability to recognize people that they have only seen once.

The term "super recognizer" was first used in an article by American psychologist Richard Russell and his team in 2009. The researchers believe that less than two per cent of the population have this extraordinary skill. They think it is the opposite of "prosopagnosia" – a condition when people are unable to recognize faces at all. According to research with identical twins, super recognizers may inherit their remarkable ability from their parents rather than learning or developing it. However, they're not necessarily any more intelligent than other people.

Super recognizers are very useful to particular organizations. For example, the Metropolitan Police in London have used special memory tests to recruit a team of officers with the "superpower" of recognizing people. They frequently work with CCTV images to identify criminals who have done serious crimes like armed robberies. They can often identify people from seeing part of their face, such as their eyes or their nose, and they can recognize people from pictures taken when they were much younger. These determined officers are often better at identifying people than face recognition scanners.

Super recognizers can sometimes remember using these skills in their childhood. Elliot Porritt, who works



as a super recognizer for the Metropolitan Police, says, "When I was young, I used to watch a lot of movies with my father. I would recognize the same actor in different movies, and it would become a bit of a game remembering who they were."

People who work as recognizers are enthusiastic about their work, but it can have disadvantages, too. Porritt says, "I love my job, but it can be hard to switch off when I'm not at work. I have a memory bank of faces in my head. Sometimes I recognize a person in the supermarket – or just walking down the street. I've had to arrest people when I'm off duty."

Although there may be some drawbacks, super recognizers can be sure of one thing – when they meet a friend from kindergarten who says, "Do you remember me?", they can always give the honest answer "yes."

